

Introduction to Elementary Particles – David Griffiths

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An updated set of notes to supersede my handwritten ones in 2025.

1 A Hitchhiker's Guide to Particles

1.1 Dramatis Personae

The Standard Model includes 17 subatomic particles (but not gravity).

1. Fermions (spin 1/2)
 - 6 Leptons: $e, \mu, \tau, \nu_e, \nu_\mu, \nu_\tau$ and antileptons
 - 6 Quarks: u, d, s, c, b, t and antiquarks
2. Gauge bosons (spin 1)
 - Gluon (strong force carrier): g
 - Photon (electromagnetic force carrier): γ
 - Intermediate vector bosons (weak force carriers): W^+, W^-, Z
3. Scalar bosons (spin 0)
 - Higgs boson (gives particles mass): H

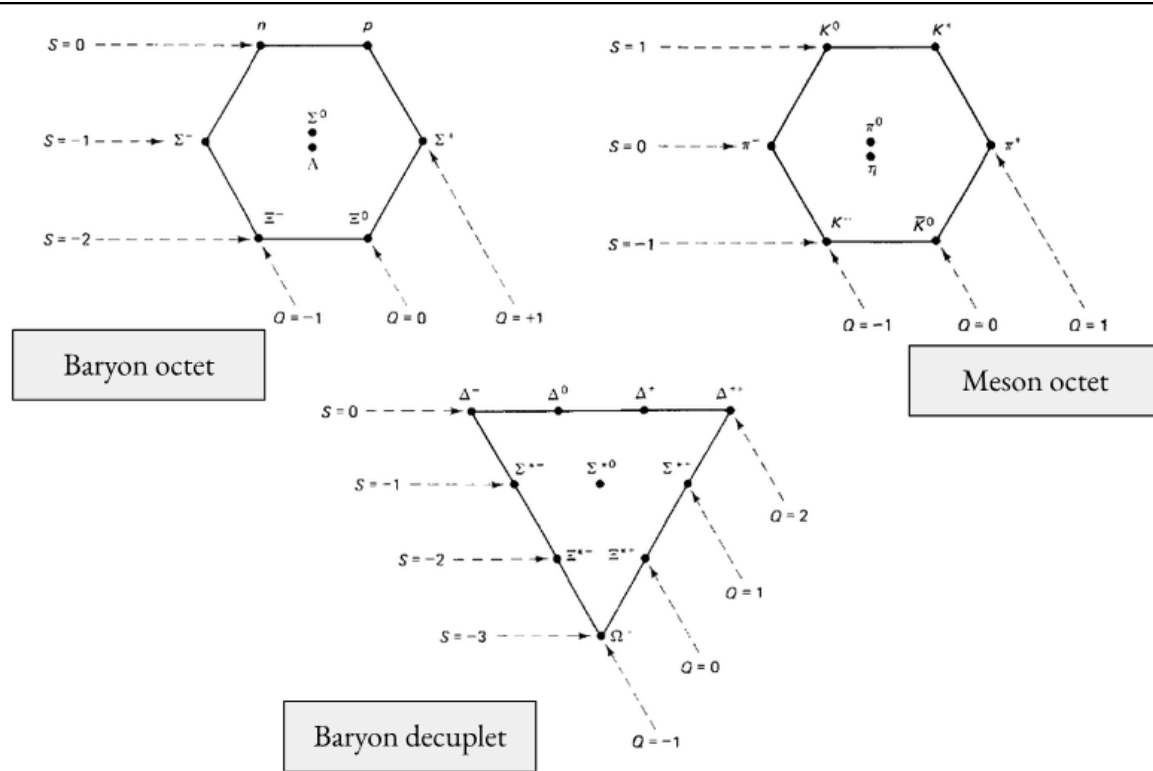
Lepton Families

	l	Q	L_e	L_μ	L_τ
1st generation	e	-1	1	0	0
	ν_e	0	1	0	0
2nd generation	μ	-1	0	1	0
	ν_μ	0	0	1	0
3rd generation	τ	-1	0	0	1
	ν_τ	0	0	0	1

Quark Families

	q	Q	D	U	S	C	B	T
1st generation	d	-1/3	-1	0	0	0	0	0
	u	2/3	0	1	0	0	0	0
2nd generation	s	-1/3	0	0	-1	0	0	0
	c	2/3	0	0	0	1	0	0
3rd generation	b	-1/3	0	0	0	0	-1	0
	t	2/3	0	0	0	0	0	1

Baryons and mesons can be organized into the baryon decuplet/octet and meson octet:



Baryon and meson octets/decuplets

1.2 Particle Dynamics

The Four Interactions

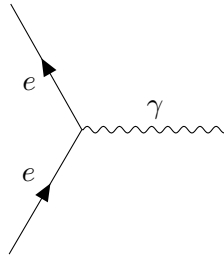
Force	Strength	Theory	Mediator
Strong	10	Chromodynamics	Gluon
Electromagnetism	10^{-2}	Electrodynamics	Photon
Weak	10^{-13}	Flavordynamics	W, Z
Gravitational	10^{-42}	Geometrodynamics	Graviton

The mediators transmit forces between 1 lepton/quark to another.

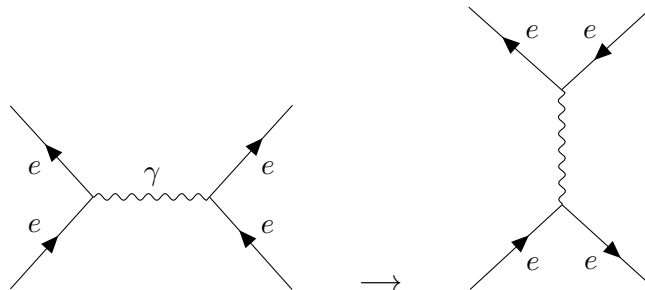
- Electromagnetism: formulated by Maxwell in 1860s.
- Quantum electrodynamics: formulated by Tomonaga, Feynman, Schwinger in 1940s.
- Weak interactions: formulated by Fermi, Lee & Yang, Feynman & Gell-Mann, etc. Until Glashow, Weinberg, Salam in 1960s.
 - GWS theory: weak & EM interactions are part of a unifying *electroweak interaction*.
- Strong interactions: formulated by Yukawa in 1930s, then others in 1970s.

1.3 Quantum Electrodynamics

All electromagnetic phenomena are reducible to the following Feynman diagram (read bottom to top):



I.e. e enters, emits/absorbs γ , and exits. The familiar Coulomb repulsion/attraction of charges (Møller scattering) is on the left. By rotating Møller scattering, we get Bhabha scattering (right): a particle-antiparticle pair annihilate, forming a photon, which later produces a particle-antiparticle pair.

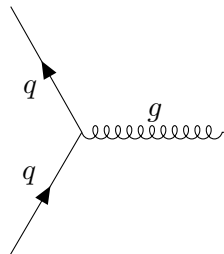


Note that only external lines describe observable particles. What goes on inside with virtual particles is allowed to violate conservation of mass, etc, as long as the external particles are all okay. Further, the lines don't accurately represent trajectories. E.g. above, the interaction might be an attraction, not repulsion. All the diagram shows is that two particles go in, interact, and two particles come out.

Each vertex introduces $\alpha = 1/137$, the coupling constant. So Feynman diagrams with many vertices, though they're physically possible, are negligible and we can sum up the possibilities.

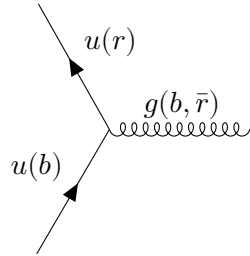
1.4 Quantum Chromodynamics

Color, not charge, causes the strong interaction. Gluons mediate the force between quarks. The fundamental vertex is

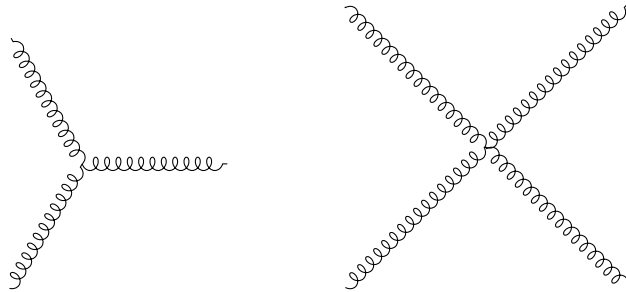


The flavor of the quark remains the same. However, color can change. E.g. blue up to red up quark,

gluon carries away difference.



Gluons themselves have color (2), so primitive gluon vertices exist (only 3-gluon and 4-gluon vertices):



The coupling constant α_S depends on the separation distance of interacting particles.

- Quark polarization drives α_S up at short distances.
- Gluon polarization drives α_S down at short distances.

$$\text{Critical parameter: } a = 2f - 11n \quad \begin{cases} a < 0 & \text{QCD coupling decreases at short dist.} \\ a > 0 & \text{QCD coupling increases at short dist.} \end{cases}$$

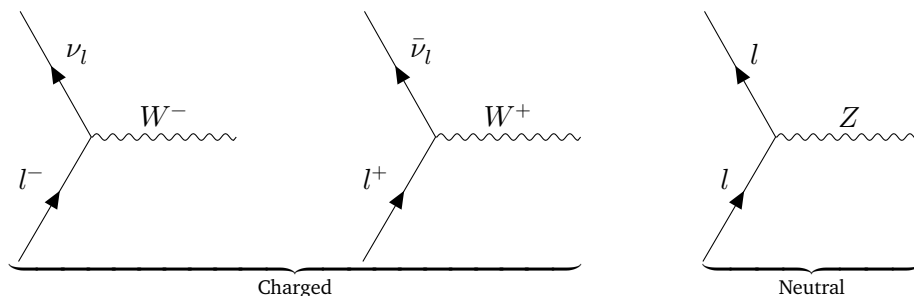
In the standard model ($f = 6$ flavors and $n = 3$ colors), $a < 0$ so QCD coupling decreases at short distances.

1.5 Weak Interactions

1.5.1 Quarks and Leptons

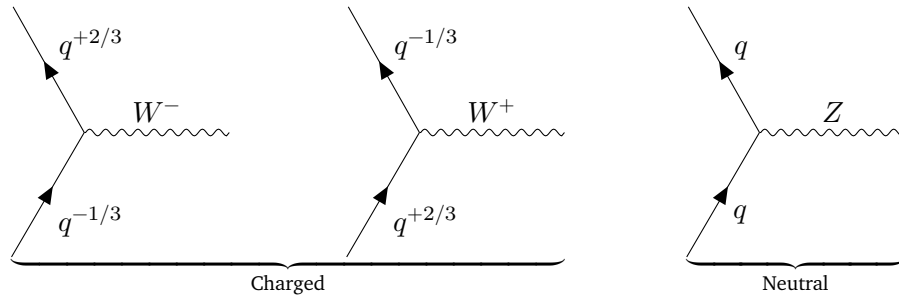
Quarks and leptons carry a “weak charge” (?) that leads to weak interactions. Weak interactions can be charged (mediated by $W^\pm$) or neutral (mediated by Z).

For leptons, the fundamental charged and neutral vertices are



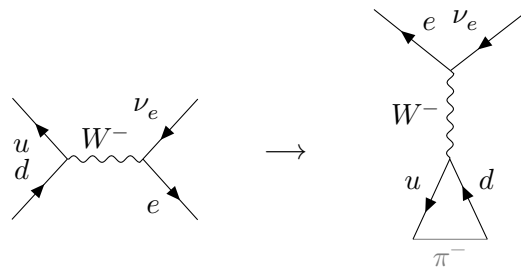
These vertices connect members to others of the **same generation**.

For quarks, same story: members of the same generation are connected (u, c, t to d, s, b , respectively). The fundamental charged and neutral vertices are

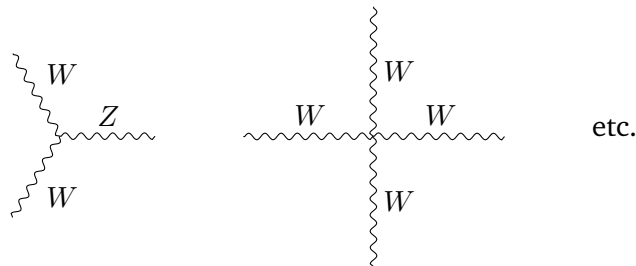


Color is conserved, but not flavor. I.e. **flavor is not conserved in weak interactions**.

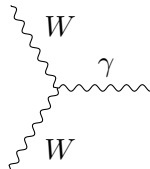
The weak interaction mediates decay. E.g. by rotating $d + \nu_e \rightarrow u + e$ (and enforcing quark confinement), we get $\pi^- \rightarrow e^- + \bar{\nu}_e$.



W and Z can also couple to each other:



Since W is charged, it can also couple to photons.



1.5.2 Skewed Quark Generations

The current available vertices don't explain strangeness-changing interactions, since the only interactions are between quarks of the same generation. Resolution: quark generations are skewed. They

couple as

$$\begin{pmatrix} u \\ d' \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} c \\ s' \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} t \\ b' \end{pmatrix}$$

where

$$\begin{pmatrix} d' \\ s' \\ b' \end{pmatrix} = \underbrace{\begin{pmatrix} V_{ud} & V_{us} & V_{ub} \\ V_{cd} & V_{cs} & V_{cb} \\ V_{td} & V_{ts} & V_{tb} \end{pmatrix}}_{\text{CKM matrix}} \begin{pmatrix} d \\ s \\ b \end{pmatrix}$$

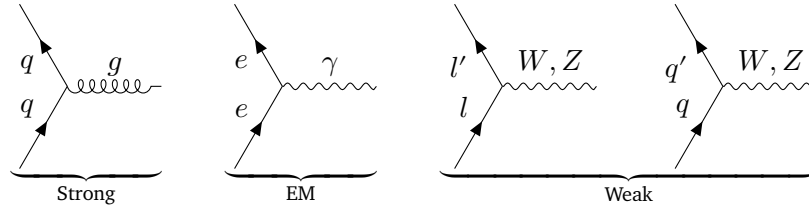
The CKM matrix is close to I , but there's some cross terms that explain strangeness-changing interactions.

1.6 Conservation Laws

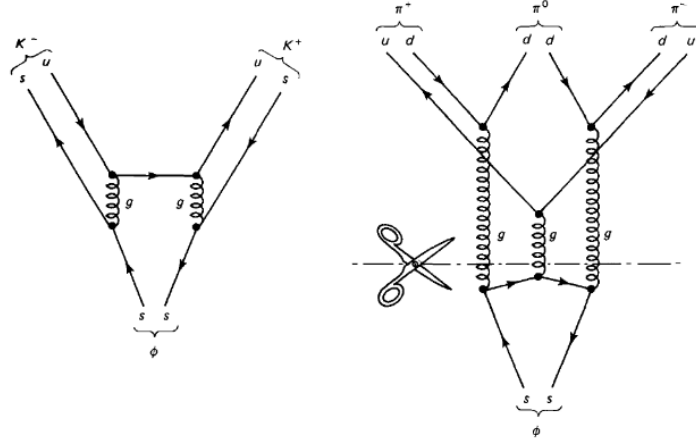
There are base kinematic conservation laws, from special relativity:

1. Conservation of energy & momentum
2. Conservation of angular momentum

There are also dynamic conservation laws for particle physics. Recall our fundamental vertices. Any quantity conserved in them must be conserved overall.



1. Conservation of charge
2. Conservation of color
3. Conservation of baryon number ($A = 1$ for baryons, $A = -1$ for antibaryons)
4. Conservation of electron number, muon number, tau number
5. Flavor is **approximately** conserved (except in weak interactions)
6. OZI rule: if a Feynman diagram can be split in two by only cutting across gluon lines, the process is suppressed.



The OZI rule explains why $\phi \rightarrow K^- + K^+$ is more common than $\phi \rightarrow \pi^- + \pi^0 + \pi^+$.

2 Special Relativity

2.1 Lorentz Transformations

The Lorentz transformations between frame S at rest and frame S' moving at v w.r.t. S :

$$\begin{aligned}
 x' &= \gamma(x - vt) \\
 y' &= y \\
 z' &= z \\
 t' &= \gamma\left(t - \frac{v}{c^2}x\right) \\
 \gamma &= \frac{1}{\sqrt{1 - v^2/c^2}}
 \end{aligned}$$

Some consequences:

1. Relativity of simultaneity: Even if $t_A = t_B$, if $x_A \neq x_B$, then $t'_A \neq t'_B$ in general.

$$t'_A = t'_B + \frac{\gamma v}{c^2}(x_B - x_A)$$

2. Length contraction: $L' = L/\gamma$

3. Time dilation: $t = \gamma t'$

4. Velocity addition formula (u is measured in S , u' is measured in S' , and v is the relative velocity between S and S')

$$u = \frac{u' + v}{1 + u'v/c^2}$$

Define the 4-vector $x^\mu = (ct, x, y, z)$ such that the Lorentz transformation becomes

$$\begin{aligned}x^{0'} &= \gamma(cx^0 - \beta x^1) \\x^{1'} &= \gamma(x^1 - \beta cx^0) \\ \beta &= \frac{v}{c}\end{aligned}$$

More simply,

$$\Lambda = \begin{pmatrix} \gamma & -\gamma\beta & 0 & 0 \\ -\gamma\beta & \gamma & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$$

$$x^{\mu'} = \Lambda^\mu_{\nu'} x^\nu$$

Define $g = \text{diag}(1, -1, -1, -1)$. (Warning: this convention is reversed from most) Then the following quantity remains constant across coordinate changes:

$$I = x_\mu x^\mu \equiv x^\mu g_{\mu\nu} x^\nu = (\Delta x^0)^2 - (\Delta x^1)^2 - (\Delta x^2)^2 - (\Delta x^3)^2$$

$x_\mu = g_{\mu\nu} x^\nu$ is the covariant 4-vector, while x^μ is the original covariant 4-vector.

1. If $a_\mu a^\mu > 0$, then a^μ is timelike.
2. If $a_\mu a^\mu < 0$, then a^μ is spacelike.
3. If $a_\mu a^\mu = 0$, then a^μ is null.

2.2 Relativistic Dynamics

Proper time is invariant; everyone agrees on it regardless of their velocity (unlike coordinate time).

$$\begin{aligned}\text{Proper time: } d\tau &= \frac{dt}{\gamma} \\ \text{Proper velocity: } \vec{\eta} &= \frac{d\vec{x}}{d\tau} = \gamma \vec{v}\end{aligned}$$

Define the relativistic energy-momentum 4-vector as follows:

$$\begin{aligned}E &= \gamma mc^2 \\ p^0 &= \frac{E}{c} = \gamma mc \\ p^i &= m\eta^i = \gamma m\vec{v} \\ p^\mu &= \left(\frac{E}{c}, p_x, p_y, p_z \right)\end{aligned}$$

The quantity $p_\mu p^\mu = E^2/c^2 - \vec{p}^2 = m^2 c^2$ is invariant.

- Rest energy: $E_r = mc^2$

- Kinetic energy: $E_K = (\gamma - 1)mc^2$
- Total energy: $E_{\text{tot}} = \gamma mc^2$

If $m = 0$, $E = |\vec{p}|c$, but what is $\vec{p}$? The answer comes from QM: $E = hf$, so

$$|\vec{p}| = \frac{hf}{c}$$

In relativistic collisions, the energy-momentum 4-vector is conserved. Thus

$$\sum p_i^\mu = \sum p_f^\mu$$

Note that the quantity $p_\mu p^\mu$ is always invariant, leading to the following equation:

$$E^2 = \vec{p}^2 c^2 + (mc^2)^2$$

3 Symmetries

3.1 Spin and Orbital Angular Momentum

Symmetries are operations that leave the system invariant. I.e. rotation by 120° on an equilateral triangle, or multiplication by I_2 on the set of 2×2 matrices.

The set of symmetry operations forms a group:

- Closed under products
- Existence of identity and inverse
- Associative

Groups in Particle Physics	
Group Name	Matrices in Group
$U(n)$	$n \times n$ unitary group, $U^*U = I$
$SU(n)$	$n \times n$ unitary group with determinant 1
$O(n)$	$n \times n$ orthogonal group, $OO = I$
$SO(n)$	$n \times n$ orthogonal group with determinant 1

Angular momentum has 2 categories: orbital angular momentum $L = rmv$ and spin angular momentum $L = I\omega$. A measurement of just L_x , L_y , or L_z affects others. Instead, we measure $\mathbf{L}^2$ along with one component, e.g. L_z .

For orbital angular momentum,

- Measuring $\mathbf{L}^2$ yields $l(l+1)\hbar^2$, for $l = 0, 1, 2, \dots$
- Measuring L_z yields $m_l\hbar$, for $m_l = -l, -l+1, \dots, l-1, l$

For spin angular momentum,

- Measuring $\mathbf{S}^2$ yields $s(s+1)\hbar^2$, for $s = 0, \frac{1}{2}, 1, \frac{3}{2}, 2, \frac{5}{2}, \dots$

- Measuring S_z yields $m_s \hbar$, for $m_s = -s, -s + 1, \dots, s - 1, s$

s is fixed for each particle, and we call it the **spin**. Fermions have half-integer spin, while bosons have integer spin.

3.1.1 Addition of Angular Momenta

To add two angular momenta, e.g. $|j_1 m_1\rangle$ and $|j_2 m_2\rangle$, where j 's are measurements of $\mathbf{J}^2$ and m 's are measurements of J_z : note that J_z adds, while $\mathbf{J}^2$ can take a range of values.

$$\begin{aligned} |j_1 m_1\rangle + |j_2 m_2\rangle &= |j m\rangle \\ j &= |j_1 - j_2|, |j_1 - j_2| + 1, \dots, |j_1 + j_2| - 1, |j_1 + j_2| \\ m &= m_1 + m_2 \end{aligned}$$

E.g. quarks and antiquarks (with spin $\frac{1}{2}$) bound with 0 angular momentum can result in a total angular momentum (j) of $\frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{2} = 1$ or $\frac{1}{2} - \frac{1}{2} = 0$. The former are the vector mesons (ρ, K^*, ϕ, ω), while the latter are the pseudo-scalar mesons (π, K, η, η').

Clebsch-Gordon tables can help with the specific decomposition amplitudes of

$$|j_1 m_1\rangle |j_2 m_2\rangle = \sum C_{m m_1 m_2}^j |j m\rangle$$

3.1.2 Spin $\frac{1}{2}$ Notation

Define spinors:

$$|\frac{1}{2} \frac{1}{2}\rangle = \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad |\frac{1}{2} -\frac{1}{2}\rangle = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}$$

The general state of a spin $\frac{1}{2}$ particle is a superposition:

$$\begin{aligned} \begin{pmatrix} \alpha \\ \beta \end{pmatrix} &= \alpha \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix} + \beta \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix} \\ \alpha &= \text{prob. that } S_z \text{ yields } \frac{1}{2}\hbar \\ \beta &= \text{prob. that } S_z \text{ yields } -\frac{1}{2}\hbar \end{aligned}$$

Also define the Pauli spin matrices:

$$\begin{aligned} \sigma_x &= \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \sigma_y = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & -i \\ i & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \sigma_z = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 \end{pmatrix} \\ \hat{S}_i &= \frac{\hbar}{2} \sigma_i \end{aligned}$$

Eigenvalues of $\hat{S}_i$ are the possible measurement outcomes of the angular momentum.

3.2 Parity Violation

Lee, Yang, and Wu showed that parity is not conserved in weak interactions. Let the helicity of a particle be m_s/s . If $m_s = \frac{1}{2}$, the particle is “right-handed,” if $m_s = -\frac{1}{2}$, the particle is “left-handed.”

The helicity of a particle is invariant if the particle is massless.

The helicity of neutrinos is **observed** to be fixed. All neutrinos are left-handed, and all antineutrinos are right-handed. However, the neutrino may have a small mass, so its helicity might be frame-dependent.

- There’s also CP violation, where C is charge conjugation (particle to its antiparticle).
- However, it’s conjectured through QFT that TCP (where T is time reversal) is conserved.

4 Bound States

4.1 Hydrogen, e^-p^+

We start with the Schrodinger equation:

$$i\hbar \frac{\partial \psi}{\partial t} = -\frac{\hbar^2}{2m} \nabla^2 \psi + V\psi$$

By assuming a separable solution $\psi = \psi(x, y, z)T(t)$, we can get $\psi = \psi(x, y, z)e^{-iEt/\hbar}$. Assume a spherically symmetric potential $V(r)$. Separating even further as $\psi(x, y, z) = R(r)\Theta(\theta)\Phi(\phi)$. The solutions to Θ and Φ are given by

$$P_l^{m_l}(z) = \frac{1}{2^l l!} (1-z^2)^{m_l/2} \left(\frac{d}{dz} \right)^{l+m_l} (z^2-1)^l \quad (\text{Legendre function})$$

$$Y_l^{m_l}(\theta, \phi) = \sqrt{\frac{2l+1}{4\pi} \frac{(l-m_l)!}{(l+m_l)!}} (-1)^{m_l} P_l^{m_l}(\cos \theta) e^{im_l \phi} \quad (\text{Spherical harmonic})$$

Introduce $u(r) = rR(r)$ to get the radial Schrodinger equation. The potential includes a centrifugal barrier of $\mathbf{L}^2/2mr^2 = l(l+1)\hbar^2/2mr^2$.

$$-\frac{\hbar^2}{2m} \frac{d^2 u}{dr^2} + \left[V(r) + \frac{\hbar^2}{2m} \frac{l(l+1)}{r^2} \right] u = Eu$$

$$\psi = T(t)R(r)\Theta(\theta)\Phi(\phi) = e^{-iEt/\hbar} u(r) Y_l^{m_l}(\theta, \phi)$$

Hydrogen (e^-p^+) has allowed energy levels at

$$E_n = -\frac{me^4}{2\hbar^2 n^2} = -\alpha^2 \frac{mc^2}{2n^2} \quad , \quad \alpha = \frac{e^2}{\hbar c} \approx \frac{1}{137}$$

The emitted wavelength can take values of

$$E = hf = -\frac{me^4}{2\hbar^2} \left(\frac{1}{n_i^2} - \frac{1}{n_f^2} \right)$$

Thus the full wavelength spectrum can be calculated, with R as the Rydberg constant. Bohr's hydrogen model successfully matched empirical observations of the previous Rydberg model.

$$\frac{1}{\lambda} = R \left(\frac{1}{n_f^2} - \frac{1}{n_i^2} \right) \quad , \quad R = \frac{mc^4}{4\pi\hbar^3}$$

4.2 Corrections to the Hydrogen Model

4.2.1 Fine Structure (Relativistic, Spin-Orbit Coupling)

From perturbation theory, given a classical Hamiltonian H and changes ΔH , energy levels change as $\Delta E_j \approx \langle \Delta H \rangle_j$. The fine structure of hydrogen is largely due to 2 factors: relativistic effects and spin-orbit coupling.

1. **Relativistic correction:** by expanding $T_{\text{rel}} = \sqrt{\mathbf{p}^2 c^2 - (mc^2)^2} - mc^2$, we get the lowest order correction to H to be

$$\Delta H_{\text{rel}} = -\frac{\mathbf{p}^4}{8m^3c^2}$$

Then by calculating expectation values,

$$\Delta E_{\text{rel}} \approx -\alpha^4 mc^2 \frac{1}{4n^2} \left[\frac{2n}{(l + \frac{1}{2})} - \frac{3}{2} \right]$$

2. **Spin-orbit coupling:** From the electron's POV, the proton rotates around it, creating a magnetic field. The proton's "current" is $I = e/(2\pi r/v)$. In Gaussian units, the magnetic field is

$$B = \frac{2\pi I}{cr} = \frac{ev}{cr^2} = \frac{e}{mcr^3} \mathbf{L}$$

The magnetic dipole is $\vec{\mu} = -(e/mc)\vec{S}$. Thus the energy of the magnetic dipole is

$$E = -\vec{\mu} \cdot \vec{B} = \frac{e^2}{m^2 c^2 r^3} (\vec{L} \cdot \vec{S})$$

There's another subtle effect: **Thomas precession**, which introduces a 1/2 factor from the Lorentz transformations to follow the motion of the electron's frame. Thus

$$\Delta H_{\text{so}} = \frac{e^2}{2m^2 c^2 r^3} (\vec{L} \cdot \vec{S})$$

After calculating expectation values,

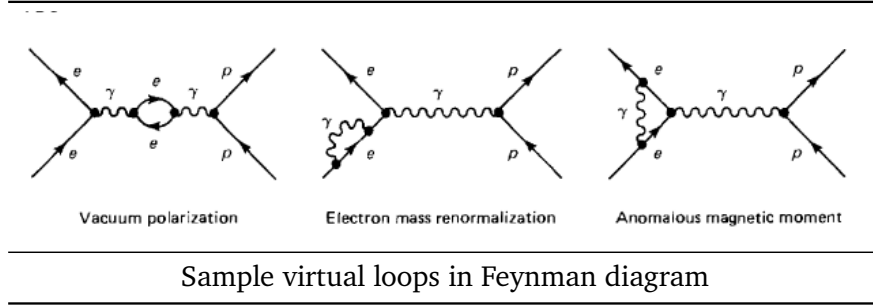
$$\Delta E_{\text{so}} = \alpha^4 mc^2 \frac{[j(j+1) - l(l+1) - \frac{3}{4}]}{4n^3 l (l + \frac{1}{2}) (l + 1)}$$

Together, the fine-structure correction is

$$E_{\text{fs}} = \alpha^4 mc^2 \frac{1}{4n^2} \left[\frac{2n}{(j + \frac{1}{2})} - \frac{3}{2} \right]$$

4.2.2 Lamb Shift

The quantization of the electromagnetic field itself leads to corrections. Vacuum loops in the Feynman diagram of the electron-proton model lead to small changes in the energy level.



$$\Delta E_{\text{Lamb}} = \begin{cases} \alpha^5 mc^2 \frac{1}{4n^3} \{k(n, 0)\} & l = 0 \\ \alpha^5 mc^2 \frac{1}{4n^3} \left\{ k(n, l) \pm \frac{1}{\pi(j+\frac{1}{2})(l+\frac{1}{2})} \right\} & l \neq 0, j = l \pm \frac{1}{2} \end{cases}$$

Where $k(n, l) \leq 0.05$.

4.2.3 Hyperfine Structure

The spin of the nucleus contributes a small correction as well. The dipole moment is similar to the one used in spin-orbit coupling, but with a γ_p factor to account for the higher angular momentum.

$$\vec{\mu}_p = \gamma_p \frac{e}{m_p c} \vec{S}_p$$

Let $\mathbf{F} = \mathbf{L} + \mathbf{S}_e + \mathbf{S}_p = \mathbf{J} + \mathbf{S}_p$ be the total angular momentum of the atom with quantum numbers f and m_f . Then the correction is

$$\Delta E_{\text{hf}} = \left(\frac{m}{m_p} \right) \alpha^4 mc^2 \frac{\gamma_p}{2n^3} \frac{\pm 1}{(f + \frac{1}{2})(l + \frac{1}{2})}, \quad f = j \pm \frac{1}{2}$$